

The Moral Privilege of True Love*

true

Abstract

In this paper, I articulate the importance of writing love songs for marginalized groups. Narrative thinking is substantial in our lives as it provides ways of thinking about how our lives may have gone differently, and how our lives may go differently. However, some may argue that this view assumes a sense of moral autonomy not available to some social classes, for instance victims of racism and other forms of societal marginalization. As a moral technology, I argue that narratives in music define plausible alternatives for such groups. I look at two classes of music, Christian Hip-Hop and popular Hip-Hop and argue that one includes plausible future plans as these refer to, most notably, the plans we have regarding ourselves, i.e., our identity, and our relationships to others. In other words, narratives in music sometimes is a study of the possible core values of the members of a musical community. These considerations provide a novel way of thinking about how our lives may go differently and how narratives in entertainment may promote these ways of thinking.

Introduction

We often question what morality is. These discussions usually invoke questions about what behaviors are appropriate, when we should be kind, what kindness entails etc. With some exceptions however, we do not consider the context in which a question about acceptable behavior makes sense. For instance, assuming that Jill is the last sentient creature on a far away planet, it may not make sense to ask what Jill's ethical obligations are to those around her. But contexts regarding questions are important. Given questions about morality, our concerns are largely about how we should behave toward others. As such, questions about moral behavior make sense in the context of our behavior towards others.

Moral psychology refers to our attempts to understand what is possible in regard to our behaviors and actions. There are two questions, what kind of creatures are we, and which behaviors are available to us. Normative theory refers to our attempts to understand what our moral obligations are, which behaviors and actions are required of us. It assumes, in part, an understanding of who we are, and which behaviors and actions we are capable of. The way normative theory and moral psychology are compared then, is that when talking about moral obligation, one assumes that an individual only has an obligation when a required behavior is available to her. The other assumes that any good normative theory will only posit actions that are available to us.

There is a middle ground however. It also begins with two questions. The first is what we can do now to make future actions possible or impossible. The second asks whether we have an obligation now to make decisions that will make future actions possible or impossible. Following these questions, there are two categories of questions. One about our physical environments and how that environment

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makes possible, certain future actions. For example, consider Jill, the daughter of poor immigrants. Jill recognizes an obligation to give substantial amounts of wealth to charity. Therefore, Jill may have an obligation to pursue a high-compensation career.

The social version of this question is more opaque. It is a question about our social environments and to what extent our social environments can provide us with the resources necessary to fulfill our moral obligations. Once again, there are two categories of question here. For instance, consider our choices as to what kind of careers would make fulfilling our moral obligations possible. If we recognize a moral obligation to give vast amounts of wealth to charity, then we could pursue a set of social connections (work hard in high school and get into a good university) that would make our ability to fulfill this obligation more likely. The other category of question is even more difficult however. It begins as a question about ourselves and the sources of our beliefs as to what is possible, or obligatory. We would start with a question about what is true about ourselves. Related to this is a question about what extent do those around us contribute to our beliefs about what is true about ourselves and what is obligatory in regard to our behavior. If we consider that we have a moral obligation to support national health, then there are some political parties we might campaign on behalf of and others we would not. Some philosophers have argued that how we should understand such questions is in the form of a narrative.

In his paper *Narrative Thinking, Emotion, and Planning*, Peter Goldie provides a possible way to combine moral psychology and normative theory. He argues that narrative is substantial in our lives as it provides ways of thinking about how our lives may have gone differently, or may go differently and why; our plans for the future; and how things might turn out. Thinking in this way leads to regret if we are disappointed in a particular choice we have made. Our feelings of regret can cause us to behave differently in the future. In part then, questions about narrative thinking may be questions about moral agency.

Importantly, the possible prospect of being able to imagine today what a morally good life will look like for us tomorrow, is a question about how what we believe about ourselves today, including what desires we have, influence our ability to pursue these ways of being. Imagining what kind of person our spouse will be can perhaps open up some romantic possibilities while closing others. Imagining where we will buy our first home may restrict our career choices, just like imagining how many children we will have may affect where we want to live. We might imagine rearing our children on the same street we learned to ride a bike, and imagine taking our family three doors down to our parents' house for Sunday dinner. As such, we might decline graduate school and instead pursue a popular industry closer to where we went to middle school.

This concept of narrative thinking and planning is also important for goal formation. We can develop a sense of agency when what we imagine plays a role in the way things turn out for us. The image of ourselves performing a life-saving surgery on a patient may give us the extra motivation we need to stay awake long hours in preparation for becoming a surgeon.

More importantly, we can develop a sense of agency when we imagine ways in which our friendships, family ties, and other important relationships will go. We can imagine the type of person we are to others and take needed steps for becoming that person. As such, the person we will be and how we will relate to others is the goal that is formed by a narrative. Consider one particular narrative, we imagine ourselves as thoughtful, kind, considerate, loving, or compassionate. Imagining ourselves this way becomes the motivation we need to read up on the latest parenting methods. We might imagine ourselves being invited to witness the birth of a friend's first child and scour the internet for advice on how to be a better gift giver. We might imagine ourselves handing a hot cup of tea

to a friend who is facing an impending divorce and read the latest books on divorce and counseling others through hard times.

While the argument that the way we imagine our lives going can have a positive causal effect on the kind of person we become, one may argue that this view is too optimistic. To what extent do the experiences we have, shape the person we become? For instance, Eric J. Miller (2020) argues that victimhood imposes normative standards that ground the moral status of the victim. What he means is that social roles, such as victim, determine the values we are expected to live by. As a victim, there are various normative standards imposed on us that undermine our ability to imagine other parenting styles and values, such as those relating to how we protect and nourish our children. Libertarian values may be those we are less apt to promote in our homes. One reason is that when victims as parents, or the parents of victims, instruct a child, they must instruct them to act in self-subordinating ways “when confronted by the police” [221] rather than in ways that assert their autonomy. While there is much that can be stressed on this point, what is important, is that a theory of narrative identity may attempt to absolve the tension by defining the agency of the would-be victim in some other way that does not involve victimhood. For instance, we may think that self-subordination is largely defined by a narrative arc, what is sub-ordination in one context, is taking ownership of one’s actions in another, taking responsibility over what one does, or did and what another may be tempted to do. This narrative arc gives meaning to a sequence of events the narrative is comprised of. What the events mean then, is largely determined by that narrative Schechtman (1996).

Narrative Thinking, Planning, and Agency

When we make plans for the future, we are often constrained in various ways. These ways may include facts about ourselves, we may not be tall enough to go on a given amusement park ride. Or have the necessary professional qualifications for a given job on the coast. Sometimes we are constrained by contingent facts about ourselves. These can include our personalities, our character traits, our emotional health and dispositions, or our abilities. Other times these constraints are external, such as past events. We can be permanently injured from a previous automobile accident. Inflation and the economy can prevent us from taking a vacation this year. We can be constrained by other people, as when someone rear-ends us and instead of driving to Yosemite, we have to get our car fixed. We can be constrained by the plans that others may have for themselves, and by extension, us; say in the case of marriage. Sometimes we are constrained by another’s personal policies, for instance, because we do not profess religious faith, our friend’s felt obligations to their religious parents may prevent them from accepting our marriage proposal.

Past experiences are connected to counterfactual thinking and regrets. The ways we reflect on these experiences and how we are constrained by them can sometimes lead to counterfactual thinking and regrets. We can regret the fact that our friend’s parents do not think of us as a legitimate suitor.

There are times wherein these constraints, experiences and the regrets they lead to are real, occurring and constraining our choices in real-life. Goldie, however, argues that there are also times that while the constraints and regrets take place in real-life, the experience is make-believe or some other fictional event, what he calls non-local events. Non-local events are ones that take place in the past, future or make-believe, but both can be a part of a fiction. Both the real-life experiences, and the fictional ones are conveyed through narratives. A narrative is a representation of a sequence of events, whether actual, or make-believe. We can imagine someone telling us a fictional account of a purported historical event. Imagine that a friend, as a prank, calls you and tells you that he saw a

random DUI check point on the way you normally take home from work and so you decide to take a different route. Through his fictional narrative, your friend has represented a sequence of events to you that constrained your choices.

We can represent both real-life and make-believe events through narrative and both can constrain our choices in real-life. More specifically, a narrative is the mental representation of a sequence of events. These can be a sequence of thoughts, thought through, and conceived of by both the narrator and the audience. The narrative can represent timelines which can be conscious or subconscious and they can provide coherence of the causal and other connections between events into what is called a narrative episode or episodes. We might imagine a counterfactual timeline wherein we wait in traffic over an hour, completely missing our dinner reservation and much needed time with our spouse. As such, these constraints can motivate feelings of regret, say that because of your alternate route, you are now late to dinner with your spouse.

What we can glean from these episodes are coherence, meaningfulness, and emotional importance/import. In imagining the counterfactual where we sit in traffic for over an hour, we may realize that we are really looking forward to having dinner with our spouse. We might realize that we have both been working really late and have not set enough time apart for each other. Goldie says that emplotment, is a psychological process which can be more or less successful. Emplotment occurs for those implicated in the narrative and those who engage with the narrative. Through emplotment, narratives give those who are implicated by them and those who engage with them, ways to consciously or subconsciously think about the events mentally represented by that narrative.

You consider how much time would be added to your commute if you went the way home that you normally would. The story your friend has told you, comes with some emotional baggage then. Realizing that you miss your spouse, you regret that you might miss your dinner reservation etc. This emotional baggage, and not the actual conditions, in part, is what determines the appropriateness of your response, whether you will take your usual way, or the other. Assuming you decide to avoid the fake DUI check-point, your response is emotionally appropriate because it is a response to how much you miss your spouse. Assuming that missing the dinner reservation equates to what most of us think of as a negatively valenced experience, taking the longer route would be the appropriate response in this situation. As such, this decision is emotionally important.

II. Emotional Import

But when we think about this emotional import, the effect on our behavior may differ from the emotional import of a real-life but non-local event and a make-believe non-local event. This implies though, that the proper response to a situation is outlined by the emotional response to a given event whether true or make-believe. Especially because it seems that it is the narrative that outlines the proper emotional response and not real-life. Both narratives are non-local events, but one is real-life and the other make-believe. Our friend may say to us; “oh man, you don’t wanna go that way let me tell you . . .”, at which point he spins a yarn about his commute taking one and a half hours longer than it does normally and it is this yarn that motivated your counterfactual experiences and subsequent feelings of regret. As such

1. Narratives first seem to outline the proper emotional response to a given event.

But, then they are also,

2. Distinct from emotions that are an agent’s response to a given event or sequence of events. (See Goldie 2009, 98)

The distinction then is between emotional import and emotional response. We ought to contrast these two features.

1. Emotional import is an integral part of the narrative
2. emotional response is a response to it

We may have felt the fear in our friend's voice or seen the frustration on his face while he tells the story. If he is even somewhat adequate at doing so, it is us who feels the same frustration. We are transplanted into the story where as the character, we experience the apt emotions, but we can also experience emotions externally. The external emotions that we experience are not as necessary. Assuming that I am drawn into the narrative, I have one emotional experience, the one that is apt in the context. However, as an audience member, I can also have emotional experiences that are responses to my response in the story. I might read Anne Frank and I am drawn into her narrative experiencing the emotions that are apt in that context. However, as an external audience member, in response to the pain and fear that I feel internally, my external response is one of anger.

Where they differ

This can similarly occur in real-life personal narratives as well. We can imagine an office employee being humiliated at a team meeting by a senior member of the team and then recalling his humiliation later that evening, he responds emotionally with anger and rage. Here, the agent as character was humiliated by a more senior member at work and in the moment, all they could feel is humiliation, embarrassment, and shame. However, taking an external perspective on what happened, they "might conceive of what happened as deserving anger and resentment."

By thinking through these narratives, we make the emotions appropriate in response to the narrative. This can occur with dramatic irony, the narrator is not aware of crucial facts about what happened until later and as such, the external emotion, the one in response to the internal emotion is different from the internal one.

Narrative Thinking and Planning

Counterfactual imagining occurs in the same way. When we imagine who we want to be, we may begin by thinking of what steps we can actively take to become that person. If we imagine ourselves to be financially independent, we may choose a college major in a field that promises a large salary. However, sometimes, once we set out on a path to becoming the person we desire, external constraints can reveal to us the feasibility of our goals. Upon entering university, we may have thought that we wanted a career in computer science but realizing how difficult the math is, we may think it is not worth it. Other factors can also constrain our choices.

There are two kinds of factors, positive and negative ones. A negative constraint is one wherein we pursue computer science but struggle with the math and decide we would rather study philosophy. A positive constraint however, is one wherein while we may be okay doing the math required by the CS field, it would detract too much from what we really liked about CS which is the analytic structure of argument. It turns out that what we liked in computer science was the logic and not so much the math. Therefore we switch majors to philosophy instead. This is an example of a positive constraint. We discover some additional desire that we have and this constrains our choice. We realize that we want to become a physician and do humanitarian work in an organization like doctors without borders. We recognize that this will require many hours of study and does not promise a large salary. As such, it would leave us with very little time for romantic relationships

and there is no financial compensation to justify the time away from loved ones. Therefore, we breakup with our college girlfriend. The positive constraint highlights an emerging goal or desire. This emerging goal or desire reveals new steps that we should take including breaking up with our girlfriend.

The steps here being referenced are hypothetical imperatives, they are imperatives about what we should do given our stated goals. While hypotheticals imperatives are implied by positive constraints, there is not initially a similar object with respect to negative constraints. For instance, we may think that negative constraints are associated not with *oughts*, but with *ought-nots*, but it is not clear.

- Hypotheticals imperatives == oughts in light of stated goals
- When you fall short of these goals, you experience negative emotions.
- the negative emotions motivate counterfactual thinking, thinking back to the crucial moment that contributed to your failure to realize your goals
- Regret is an external emotion that arises in response to your decision underlying your goal failure
- Each, negative emotions, counterfactual narrative thinking, and regrets can have a feedback effect on one's grasp of the related hypothetical imperatives, helping one to learn from one's mistakes. Negative emotions then motivate counterfactual thinking.

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